

‘yo’ to the rescue

Getting started with Yeoman, a scaffolding tool for web apps

Agnibha Bose | feedback@digit.in

Yeoman is a scaffolding tool that helps you kick-start new projects and pre-scribes the best

practices and tools to help you stay productive. In order to achieve that goal, Yeoman basically provides you with a generator ecosystem that helps to scaffold either a complete project or at least some part of it.

WHAT IS SCAFFOLDING AND WHY DO I NEED IT?

This concept basically came from Ruby, another very popular programming language where you can say something like `rails generate scaffold model_name` and it would basically generate the required code that your application would need to interact with the system. This is something like maven archetypes if you are coming from a Java background.

WHEN TO USE YEOMAN?

It's good to use Yeoman when you want to create an application that requires some basic configuration. Suppose there are similar types of projects being developed at your office and you know that there are some basic codes required to start off with the application, then you can create a generator for that. There are a lot of community-made generators available that can help you to scaffold the project. You can find all of the official generators on their website or by going to:

<http://yeoman.io/generators/>

Here, we are primarily focusing on how to create a generator. So the basic requirement of this article is some preliminary knowledge about nodejs and JavaScript, specifically ES6. All of the code that is written over here is following ES6 Syntax whenever possible. You need to have nodejs and npm installed on your system to follow along with this tutorial.

SETTING UP THE GENERATOR

First check whether you have nodejs installed in your system by typing

```
$ node -v
```

If you don't have nodejs installed, do so from <https://nodejs.org/en/>

Next, you have to install Yeoman. Because it's an npm package, this is simple:

```
$ npm i -g yeoman
```

Now, the Yeoman team has created a generator in order to create generators! To install this, you will need to use npm:

```
$ npm i -g generator-generator
```

Note: If you face any kind of access rule limits then you must run the above commands with admin access.

After you are done with the steps above, you can now create your own generator. Our goal is to create a basic express application. First you have to run the generator that you just installed, in the directory where you want to create the generator.

```
$ yo generator
```

After running the above command you will be greeted with the basic prompt for Yeoman. Prompting is a very important concept in Yeoman.

```
~/PSC/YeomanTuts % 3:09:31
$ mkdir test

~/PSC/YeomanTuts % 3:09:36
$ cd test

~/PSC/YeomanTuts/test % 3:09:36
$ yo
'Allo Agnibha! What would you like to do? Yeoman Tuts
Make sure you are in the directory you want to scaffold into.
This generator will play be run with yo yeoman-tuts

Welcome Agnibha to the
astounding
generator-yeoman-tuts
generator!

Please provide your name Agnibha
Please provide your email id agnibha@digit.com
Please provide your app name defaultyeoman
Please enter the port number in which you would like to run the app 3000
Please choose one of the license Apache 2.0

(node package.json
create view/view.html
create app/app.js
default:localhost:3000 /home/agnibha/PSC/YeomanTuts/test
- express@4.15.4
```

After running the generator

You will be asked to give some basic information about the generator here.

The generator also creates a folder and performs the necessary npm installation. Additionally, there are some nifty features using inquirer.js where you can provide some checkboxes and various dropdowns and styles in your generator to enhance the user experience.

After everything is done the file structure should look like this:

```
generator-yeoman-tuts
├── generators
│   ├── app
│   │   └── index.js
│   └── templates
│       └── dummyfile.txt
├── LICENSE
├── package.json
├── README.md
└── tests
```

If we were to describe the folder structure, then the folder that you should be interested in is the generators folder. There is basically only one folder in the generators folder and that is your app folder. This folder contains the necessary files that are required to start off with your generator. The index.js contains the logic to run your generator and the templates folder